

MASTER COMPENDIUM: MODERN SEO & GEO WORKFLOWS

Complete Technical Blueprint for Search Engine & Generative Engine Optimization (2026)

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

- SECTION 1: SEO 2026 Strategy Tier List
- SECTION 2: Google Search Console Question Extraction Hack
- SECTION 3: The 30-Day SEO + GEO Roadmap for New Websites
- SECTION 4: From Zero to Master: The 6-Step Keyword & Competitor Framework
- SECTION 5: Deep Dive: GEO/AEO Architecture & RAG Mechanics

SECTION 1: SEO 2026 STRATEGY TIER LIST

Source: Harry Sanders (@HARRYSANDERSSEO)

This tier list evaluates modern search optimization tactics based on their actual impact in AI-driven search environments and large language model retrieval pipelines.

TIER	TACTIC	STRATEGIC RATIONALE & IMPACT
S TIER	Topical Authority	Essential for ranking in modern AI search platforms. Defines whether your domain is recognized as an expert hub.
S TIER	Original Data & Research	AI search engines are forced to cite your site as a primary source when you provide unique research and primary metrics.
S TIER	Digital PR	A top-tier strategy for securing high-authority brand mentions, media press, and high-quality backlink signals.
A TIER	Internal Linking	High-value tactic that remains underleveraged. Distributes page equity and maps architectural relationships for AI crawlers.
B TIER	EEAT Signals	Useful as a general quality standard, but functions as a broad quality concept rather than a standalone ranking tactic.
C TIER	Schema Markup	Has utility for machine readability, but modern AI models parse unstructured page context without strictly relying on JSON-LD.
D TIER	Domain Authority	A third-party metric created by software tools. It does not reflect Google's internal algorithm or direct ranking factors.
F TIER	PageSpeed Micro-Optimization	Beyond meeting baseline speed thresholds (under 3s), micro-optimizing load times delivers zero incremental ranking impact.

Execution Protocols for Top Tactic Execution

S-TIER STRATEGY 1: TOPICAL AUTHORITY

Methodology: Build topic clusters consisting of one broad pillar page linked to 10 to 20 granular supporting articles. Cover all sub-topics, edge cases, and user questions to eliminate content gaps. Avoid publishing off-topic content that dilutes domain focus.

S-TIER STRATEGY 2: ORIGINAL DATA & PROPRIETARY RESEARCH

Methodology: Extract anonymized metrics from your own operational platforms, run industry surveys with 100 to 500 respondents, and format stat callouts prominently in bold text (e.g., **68% of users prefer X**). This allows AI scrapers to extract exact figures easily and cite your domain as the primary source.

S-TIER STRATEGY 3: DIGITAL PR

Methodology: Package original research into press pitches for media journalists, engage in newsjacking by submitting expert quotes to breaking stories, and launch free web micro-tools (calculators, utilities) that publishers naturally link to.

A-TIER STRATEGY: ADVANCED INTERNAL LINKING

Methodology: Connect sub-topic articles directly back to their parent pillar page, cross-link related sub-topics, and use descriptive, keyword-rich anchor text. Identify top-performing pages in Google Search Console and link from them to strategic money pages.

SECTION 2: GOOGLE SEARCH CONSOLE QUESTION EXTRACTION HACK

Source: Coach Tommy G (@COACHTOMMY.G)

This workflow uses Google Search Console's native Regular Expression (Regex) engine to filter and extract all question-based search queries that bring users to your website.

Step-by-Step Implementation Workflow

1. Open **Google Search Console** and navigate to the **Performance** tab.
2. Click **+ Add filter** and select **Query**.
3. Change the dropdown mode to **Custom (regex)** → **Matches regex**.
4. Paste the custom Regex string provided below into the box and click **Apply**.
5. Analyze the list of actual questions users type before visiting your site. Use these exact questions to structure new H2 sections, blog topics, and dedicated FAQ modules.

GSC QUESTION FILTERING REGEX STRING

```
(?i) .* (who|what|when|where|why|how|which|whose|whom|can|could|should|would|will|is|are|am|do|does|did|have|has|had|may|might) .*
```

SECTION 3: THE 30-DAY SEO + GEO ROADMAP FOR NEW WEBSITES

Source: Ghulam Ali SEO ("The 30-Day SEO+GEO Roadmap For New Websites")

A structured 4-week execution framework designed to establish technical foundations while positioning new websites for Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) and AI citations in tools like ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Perplexity.

Week 1: Technical Foundation & Findability

- **Search Consoles:** Connect domain to Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools (Bing's index directly feeds Copilot and ChatGPT search).
- **XML Sitemaps:** Generate XML sitemaps via an SEO plugin (SEOPress, Rank Math, or Yoast) and submit `sitemap.xml` to both consoles.
- **Robots.txt Audit:** Verify that `robots.txt` does not block Googlebot or major AI search agents (GPTBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot).
- **Technical Health Baseline:** Ensure load times are under 3 seconds, mobile responsiveness is complete, and SSL (HTTPS) is active.
- **Query Benchmarking:** Search target niche topics in AI engines to identify currently cited competitor websites.

Week 2: Core Content Building

- **Quality Focus:** Publish 5 to 10 comprehensive, high-value pages rather than pumping out dozens of thin articles.
- **Answer-First Rule:** Provide direct definitions or core answers in the first 40 to 60 words under every heading.
- **Competitor Depth Analysis:** Study top-ranking competitor pages, cover all sub-topics, and add missing insights or unique data.
- **Scannable Structure:** Implement clear H2/H3 tags, short paragraphs (2 to 3 sentences max), comparison tables, bullet points, and dedicated FAQ sections.
- **Evidence & Schema:** Support all claims with specific stats, link to primary sources, connect pages via internal links, and deploy JSON-LD Schema.

Week 3: GEO Layer (AI Citation Optimization)

- **Self-Contained Q&A Blocks:** Add standalone H3 question headings followed by concise 2 to 3 sentence answers tailored for AI extraction.
- **Off-Site Footprint:** Participate in active niche forums, Reddit, Quora, and business directories to build third-party web consensus.
- **Content Freshness:** Maintain current stats and visible dates; LLMs prioritize recently updated sources over stagnant content.

Week 4: Measurement, Tracking & Content Refresh Loop

- **Prompt Tracking:** Run 10 to 20 target customer prompts in ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, and Claude to monitor brand citations.
- **Impression Monitoring:** Track Search Console for keywords ranking on pages 2 and 3.
- **Content Refresh Loop:** Audit near-ranking or cited pages, adding deeper answers, fresh data, updated stats, and new internal links.

SECTION 4: FROM ZERO TO MASTER: THE 6-STEP KEYWORD & COMPETITOR FRAMEWORK

Source: Ghulam Ali (@GHULAM_ALI_SEO)

A systematic framework for designing a new domain's complete 6-month SEO roadmap by reverse-engineering established competitors and mapping keyword intent.



Detailed Step Breakdown

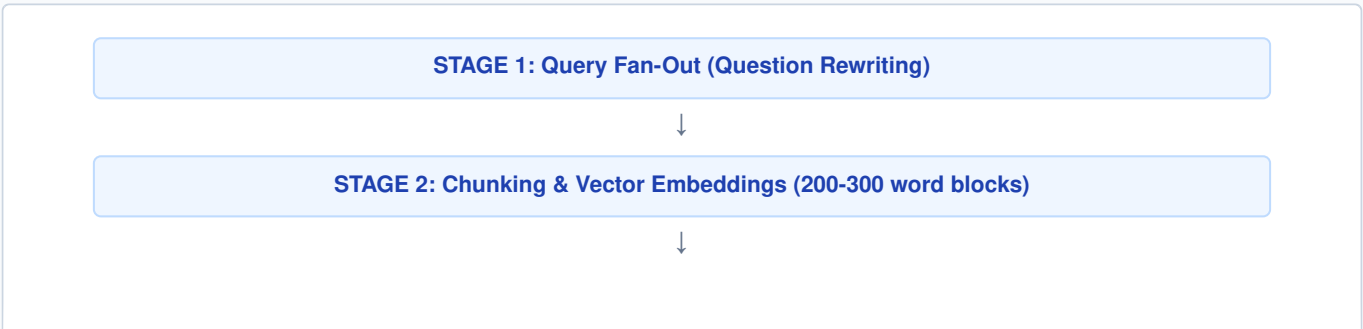
- 1. **Gather 50 Competitors:** List 50 active, relevant competitor domains operating in your exact niche vertical.
- 2. **Extract Data:** Run all competitor domains through Ahrefs or SEMrush to export their full keyword profiles.
- 3. **Map Intent & Funnel:** Categorize terms by search intent (Informational, Commercial, Transactional) and funnel level (Top, Middle, Bottom of Funnel).
- 4. **Cluster Keywords:** Group closely related keywords into dedicated topic clusters around central pillar pages.
- 5. **Analyze Feasibility:** Evaluate keyword difficulty to separate immediate quick wins (low competition) from medium and long-term targets.
- 6. **Design 6-Month Roadmap:** Construct a complete 6-month calendar where content publishing, page structure, and internal linking align with your keyword architecture.

SECTION 5: DEEP DIVE: GEO/AEO ARCHITECTURE & RAG MECHANICS

Source: Ghulam Ali SEO ("I Spent 2,000 Hours Learning GEO/AEO For This")

An advanced technical breakdown explaining how Large Language Models process web data through Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) and how to optimize content for AI recommendation engines.

The 4 Stages of Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG)



STAGE 3: Ranking Survivors & Freshness Scoring



STAGE 4: Synthesis & Output Generation

- **Stage 1: Query Fan-Out (Question Rewriting):** When a user enters a complex prompt, the AI engine breaks it down into multiple sub-queries. Content must address definitions, comparisons, and edge cases to match these fan-out sub-queries.
- **Stage 2: Chunking & Vector Embeddings:** AI scrapers retrieve specific 200 to 300 word paragraph "chunks" rather than full web pages, converting them into mathematical vector embeddings. Unstructured, messy paragraphs create messy embeddings that get ignored.
- **Stage 3: Ranking Survivors:** Retrieved chunks are scored based on clarity, relevance, authority, and content recency.
- **Stage 4: Output Synthesis & Outcomes:** Chunks are synthesized into a final answer. Content achieves one of three outcomes:
 1. *Selected:* Retrieved by the AI system.
 2. *Integrated:* Embedded directly into the response text.
 3. *Absorbed:* Information is used without giving your site credit.

The Core GEO Objective: Elevate content from simple absorption to explicit brand citations and link recommendations.

Princeton Study: 3 Proven Citation Boosters

Academic research on Generative Engine Optimization identified three tactics that increase AI citation frequency by up to 40%:

- **Hard Statistics:** Replace vague phrases with verifiable figures (e.g., replace "many marketers adopt X" with "25.7% of marketers adopt X").
- **Direct Attributed Quotes:** Include named quotes from credible, verifiable industry experts.
- **Primary Source Citations:** Add direct links to original research papers, government reports, or primary data sources.

The 4-Layer GEO Implementation Model

LAYER	CORE OPTIMIZATION REQUIREMENTS
Layer 1: Content Optimization	Front-load value with 40 to 60 word atomic answers in the top third of pages (44% of AI extractions occur here). Keep one concept per heading. Use listicles and comparison tables (which earn 25% higher priority than opinion posts). Include 5 to 7 dedicated Q&A pairs per page.
Layer 2: Entity & Authority	Maintain identical brand and author naming across all profiles. Implement Organization, Article, FAQPage, and Person schema with sameAs links pointing to verified entity URLs. Display clear author credentials and visible update dates.
Layer 3: Technical Layer	Ensure robots.txt permits AI agents (GPTBot, OAI-SearchBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot). Server-render HTML so crawlers do not rely on executing JavaScript. Maintain a 30-day content update cadence (pages updated within 30 days are 3x more likely to be picked by LLMs).
Layer 4: Off-Site Digital PR	AI models measure consensus across independent websites, Reddit, media outlets, and forums. Both linked and unlinked brand mentions build citation trust.

TRACKING GEO PERFORMANCE & THE ULTIMATE POWER MOVE

Track AI Share of Voice: Test 50 to 100 customer prompt variations across ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, and Perplexity to measure the percentage of AI answers recommending your brand.

The #1 Power Move (Proprietary Data): Conduct audience surveys or publish proprietary operational data. When you create unique primary data, third parties cite your work, forcing AI engines to recognize your domain as the primary source of truth.